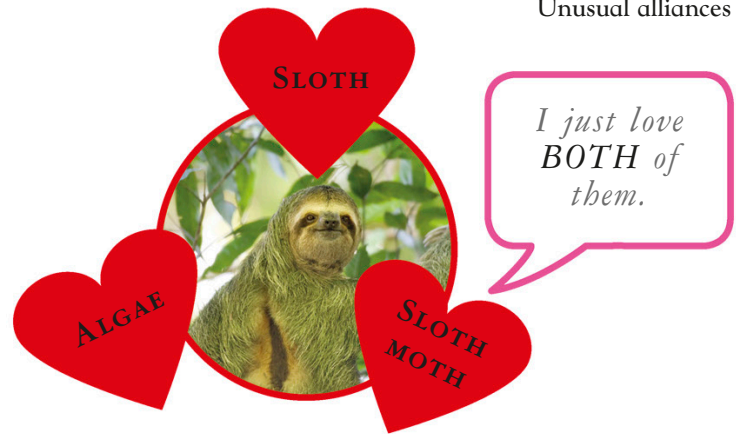




Home to many

Sloths often look as if they have green fur because of the algae growing on their outer hairs. The algae camouflage the sloth among the leaves and provide it with extra nutrients that the sloth takes in while grooming its fur. This alga lives only on sloths. There is also a moth that lives on the sloth. It eats the algae and lays its eggs in the sloth's droppings. Several other insect species live in the fur, including mites and beetles.



PERFECT PARTNERS

Sometimes a close relationship works to the benefit of both species. In some cases, the partners live separately, but gain from being

together for a period of time. Others are more dependent and one may die without the other. This type of relationship is called mutualism.

I get all that yummy nectar and she gets the pollen. It's a WIN-WIN situation for both of us.



Many flowering plants depend on insects, birds, and animals for pollination or to spread their seed. The animals are provided with food and, in turn, they help in the flower's reproductive process. Bees visit flowers to collect nectar and pollen. As they move from one flower to the next they transfer pollen, ensuring that the flower is fertilized and can set seed.

My live-in algal friends and I believe in GIVE and TAKE. But if things get tough, I'll kick them out!



Corals and lichens both play host to algae, which live in their tissues. In return for shelter and vital nutrients, the algae provide their host with some of the sugars they make through photosynthesis. Not all corals share their living space with algae, but those that do regulate how many algae they take in. When the coral gets stressed it expels the algae, but if it tries to live without them for too long, it will die.

I used to hate going to the hygienist until I came here. They're always SO HAPPY to see me.



Many species of fish rely on others to rid them of lice, fungal infections, or dead skin. On coral reefs there are often cleaning stations where big fish line up for the attentions of smaller fish or shrimp. The big fish signals so the cleaner knows it is safe to approach. The cleaner then swims in and out of its client's mouth and gills in search of tasty morsels.